weaponized for making people subservient. Rahul Gandhi keenly listened to us and understood what we were alluding to. He beamed when we told him that this particular abhang was translated by Mahatma Gandhi into English. He happily consented when we requested him to wear the traditional Gandhi cap. Even though he wanted us to continue, we took our leave, saying others were waiting for him. With a disarming smile and a warm handshake, he thanked us and bid us farewell.

In both these interactions, I found Rahul Gandhi quite unlike what he was in popular perception. He listens carefully and then makes a pithy comment that compels one to think. This sharp and direct approach Rahul uses is quite a breath of fresh air.

People could argue that this side of Rahul Gandhi may be limited to closed-door interactions, but that isn't true. I observed him in front of a live audience in Nanded, and it was an experience in itself. The way listeners were responding to what he was saying suggested that he had touched the audience's hearts. Furthermore, unlike the other leaders of the Congress party, Rahul fiercely takes on Hindutva. For example, on Birsa Munda's memorial day (15 November) Rahul bitterly attacked V.D. Savarkar, an RSS ideologue, for eighteen minutes. Arguing that Birsa Munda eschewed all enticements of land and money by the colonial government, he said that he steadfastly fought for the rights of the Adivasi. In stark contrast, he asserted that Savarkar issued numerous apology letters to the colonial government within six months of his incarceration and eventually secured a pension from the British government. Now, one can have different views on this (especially in Maharashtra, where Savarkar is venerated because he was jailed during the freedom struggle). But it takes courage to go beyond what's politically expedient and say what one believes in, which is what Rahul Gandhi did that day. Similarly, Rahul also made a sharp contrast between the BJP's use of vanvasi (forest dwellers) versus Adivasi, to describe the plight of India's Scheduled Tribes. In very simple language, he reminisced about how his grandmother (former Prime Minister Indira Gandhi) had once gifted him a book on India's tribals. She had explained that because tribals were the original dwellers of this country, he would